In this chapter, you'll see:

- An overview of the project you'll be building
- Setting up RSpec for a real project
- How to get started writing acceptance specs
- How to mark work in progress

CHAPTER 4

Starting On the Outside: Acceptance Specs

You've seen the basic parts of RSpec: example groups, examples, and expectations. Now, you're going to put those pieces together as you build and test a real application.

In this chapter, we'll pick a problem to solve and sketch out the major pieces of the solution. As you follow along, you'll create a new project and start testing it with RSpec. You'll start with *acceptance specs*, which check the behavior of the application as a whole. By the end of the chapter, you'll have the skeleton of a live app and a spec to test it—plus some clues on where to start filling in the details.

First Steps

Before we get started, we need to decide what kind of app we're going to build: an embedded system, a search engine, a Twitter clone, or what have you. We'll need to sketch out just enough pieces to decide what technologies we're going to use. Then, we can set up RSpec in our new project directory. Over the course of the project, you'll see how outside-in development helps you build a better system.

The Project: An Expense Tracker

We'll need a project big enough to contain some real-world problems, but small enough to work on over a few chapters. How about a web service for tracking expenses? Customers will use some kind of client software—a command-line app, a GUI, or even a web app—to track and report their daily expenses.